

IS 'LIE' A PROTOTYPE OR A DUAL CHARACTER CONCEPT?

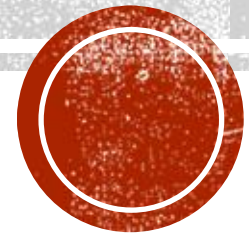
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PLAN

- Introduction: problems with the traditional definition of lying
- 'Lie' as a dual character concept
- 'Lie' as a prototype concept



ST AUGUSTINE, *DE MENDACIO*

“But none doubts that it is a lie when a person willingly utters a falsehood for the purpose of deceiving: wherefore a false utterance put forth with will to deceive is manifestly a lie.”



TRADITIONAL DEFINITION:

- a lies iff:
 1. a says p
 2. a believes that p is false
 3. a intends their audience to believe that p .

- + folk concept of lying
- + lying-misleading distinction



MODIFICATIONS

- Re 2: p is false vs p is believed to be false
- Re 1: says?
- *Ada is a keen gardener but has had an exceptionally bad crop of tomatoes. Ada wants Bill to think that her crop was in fact great, so when she meets Bill and he asks how her crop of tomatoes has been, she utters:*

I've got tomatoes coming out of my ears. (Viebahn 2017)

Re 3: a intends their audience to believe that p /that a believes that p /...



BALD-FACED LIES

- Dean

„suppose that a student is caught flagrantly cheating on an exam for the fourth time this term, all of the conclusive evidence for which is passed on to the Dean of Academic Affairs. Both the student and the Dean know that he cheated on the exam, and they each know that the other knows this, but the student is also aware of the fact that the Dean punishes students for academic dishonesty only when there is a confession. Given this, when the student is called to the Dean's office, he states, 'I did not cheat on the exam.'” (Lackey 2013)



DECEPTIONISTS

- Bald-faced lies are not genuine lies
- “The folk term “bald-faced lie” should not be mistakenly equated with the concept of a lie approached theoretically.” (Dyner 2011).



SELFLESS ASSERTION

Stella is a devoutly religious person employed as a fourth-grade teacher. Her religious views are grounded in a deep faith that she has had since childhood. Part of this faith includes a belief in the truth of creationism and, accordingly, the falsity of evolutionary theory. Despite this, Stella fully recognizes that there is an overwhelming amount of scientific evidence against creationism and in favour of evolutionary theory. Moreover, Stella does not think that religion should be imposed on fourth-grade students. Instead, she regards it as her duty as a teacher to present material that is best supported by the available evidence, which clearly includes the truth of evolutionary theory. As a result, while presenting her biology lesson today, Stella tells her students, “Modern humans evolved from more apelike ancestors called hominids.”

Lackey 2013



MODIFIED INTENTION TO DECEIVE

- Lackey 2013
- Deception: A is deceptive to B with respect to whether p if A aims to conceal information from B regarding whether p.



ADDITIONAL ADDRESSEES

- Rudnicki, Odrowąż-Sypniewska 2023: 'institutional addressees'



NONDECEPTIONISTS

- a lies iff:
 1. a says p
 2. a believes that p is false
 3. ~~a intends their audience to believe that p~~



NO INTENTION TO DECEIVE → DEFINITION NEEDS TO BE MODIFIED

- *Donald Trump is a real lion.*
- *Donald Trump is the worst human being ever.* (see Saul 2013)
- *I've got tomatoes coming out of my ears.*

Metaphor, irony, sarcasm, hyperbole



NONDECEPTIVE LIES

- a lies iff:
 1. a **asserts** that p
 2. a believes that p is false



PROBLEMS WITH ASSERTION

- Various definitions; commitment account of assertion → very broad definition of lying; no lying-misleading distinction?
- Meibauer: insincere assertion always involves intention to deceive



NO CLEAR CASES OF LIES WITH NO INTENTION TO DECEIVE

- Bald-faced lies – BUT: not assertions?, intention to deceive?
- Coercion lies – BUT: not assertions?
- Habitual lies – BUT: intention?
- ‘Lying’ to machines – BUT: intention?
- Indifferent lies - BUT: not assertions?, intention to deceive?



EXPERIMENTS

- „the most recent empirical findings do seem to speak in favor of non-deceptionism. (...) Krstić and Wiegmann (2022) tested whether ordinary speakers consider Pinocchio to be lying in uttering [“Tony definitely isn’t in my house”] and whether they take him to have an intention to deceive the police. A clear majority judged Pinocchio to be lying, and a clear majority judged him not to have an intention to deceive the police”. (Viebahn 2025)



TELL-TALE SIGN 'LIES'

Pinartio: A vicious murderer, Tony, is hiding from the police in Pinocchio's house. In search of Tony, the police knock on Pinocchio's door asking whether Tony is hiding in his house. Pinocchio wants to give Tony away but he is afraid that, if he gives any indication of this to Tony, Tony will hurt him. Luckily, Pinocchio knows both that the police know that his nose starts to grow at the very instant he forms the intention to lie and that they know that he knows that they know how his nose behaves, but that Tony does not know anything about this. Therefore, he asserts

“Tony definitely isn't in my house” to the police.

Pinocchio does this not because he intends to deceive the police in any sense (he doesn't want them to think that he is protecting a murderer), but rather because he intends to let them know that Tony *is* in his house by having them recognize the full content of his intention.

Krstić 2020, 758–759/ Krstić & Wiegmann 2022



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- „Finally, one may wonder whether our experimental results entitle us to say that the non-deceptionist analysis is the right analysis of lying. We would not go that way. The issue of whether all lies are intended to deceive is not a voting matter but rather a question that should be resolved by conceptual analysis.” (Krstić, Wiegmann 2022)



'LIE' AS A DUAL CHARACTER CONCEPT (SKOCZEN 2026)

- Bronston vs US

Samuel Bronston, the owner of Samuel Bronston Productions based in New York, made movies in various European countries to lower the movie production costs. As discovered later, he therefore kept bank accounts in 37 different countries. In 1964, after one of the company's big movie productions, *The Fall of the Roman Empire*, proved a financial catastrophe, Bronston filed for federal bankruptcy protection. During the court proceedings, Bronston was questioned under oath about his off-shore bank accounts by a lawyer representing his creditors. The following exchange ensued:

Question. Do you have any bank accounts in Swiss banks, Mr. Bronston?

Answer. No, sir.

Q. Have you ever?

A. The company had an account there for about six months, in Zürich. (Skoczeń 2021)



“Since people at least sometimes call both a false assertion and a false implicature under a unified label of a lie, there must be some common underlying criterion to all the instances we call lies. This type of conceptual structure is similar to what is called in the literature a dual character concept”. (2026: 8)

- Concrete criterion: saying something one believes to be false
- Abstract criterion: intend to mislead the hearer and extract an unfair advantage
- Perjury – the superficial, technical criterion for lying



- “What closely ties together the different criteria for lying could be the need to commit oneself to the truth of a claim, which one believes to be false” (2026: 11)
- “by saying that his company had a bank account, Bronston committed himself to the truth of the implicature that he personally had no bank account, which he believed to be false”. (2026: 12)



- Bronston:
- There is a sense in which this is clearly not a lie, but ultimately, if you think about what it really means to lie, you would have to say that this is a real lie after all.
- White lie (surprise birthday party):
- However, one could very well say that there is a sense in which this is clearly a lie, but ultimately, if you think about what it really means to lie, you would have to say that this is not a lie at all. (2026: 10)
- any layperson may have two sets of criteria to determine what is a lie (2026: 14)



EXPERIMENT

- John, a friend of the governor of the local area, took part in a festive party. John is suspected of being one of the guests who were bribed by the governor at the party, in order to make these guests vote for the governor in the elections. John is questioned under oath in the courtroom. The questioning lawyer asks John whether he received a bribe at the party. John replies: “I did not receive any money at any party.” It turns out that John received a bribe in the form of a well-paid job in the public administration at the party. (2026: 22)
- There's a sense in which what John said is technically not a lie, but ultimately, if you think about what it really means to lie, you'd have to say that there is a sense in which this was a lie after all.
- “participants always agreed with the claim that the protagonist's utterance was a real lie (even if it was not a lie in the technical sense)” (2026: 25)



INTERNAL PROBLEMS

- Perjury

The federal definition of perjury contains four main criteria:

(C1) S[peaker] makes a statement;

(C2) S does not believe p to be true;

(C3) the statement made is material and taken under oath; and

(C4) S makes the statement willfully. (2026: 2)

- Concrete criterion: saying something one believes to be false



- Commitment
- “by saying that his company had a bank account, Bronston committed himself to the truth of the implicature that he personally had no bank account, which he believed to be false”. (2026: 12)
- Commitment to p: A speaker S is committed to a proposition p being the case iff (a) S is ‘accountable’ for p, and (b) S is ‘discursively responsible’ for p (Marsili 2026: 546)



DUAL CHARACTER CONCEPTS

- Knobe, Prasada, Newman (2013)
 - (a) set of concrete features
 - (b) the abstract values that these features serve to realize
 - Concrete features realize the same abstract value
- > two bases for evaluating category membership
- > two different criteria for category membership



- There is a sense in which she is clearly not a scientist, but ultimately, if you think about what it really means to be a scientist, you would have to say that she truly is a scientist.
- Concrete: conducting experiments, analyzing data, developing theories, writing papers
- Abstract: pursuing empirical knowledge
- Possible to fulfil the concrete criteria without fulfilling the abstract ones and possible to fulfil the abstract criteria without fulfilling the concrete ones
- Concrete criteria $\approx$ prototypes
- One can fulfil the second criterion even when that person doesn't even come close to being a prototypical member of the category (Liao, Meskin, Knobe (2020: 7))



DCC

- Initially: a few selected concepts are DCC
- scientist, art, criminal, teacher, rock music, mother, love, happiness, law, belief, self, rule
- traitor, enemy, sadness (Prochownik, Almeida 2022)
- Social role concepts
- Gender terms
- Not natural kind terms
- “*True*-modifier operates on the normative dimension” (Del Pinal, Reuter)



- Various ideas about abstract values:
- Abstract value (Knobe, Prasada, Newman 2013)
- Ideal functions, ideal primary functions (Leslie 2015)
- Commitment to fulfil certain idealized functions (Del Pinal, Reuter 2017)



- Del Pinal, Reuter 2017: weak and strong dual character concepts
- A weak dcc can be turned into strong dcc (e.g. in high-devotion contexts)
- Reuter 2019: 'bus driver' can be a dcc
- Leslie 2015: coercing to take on a dual character



PHILLIPS, PLUNKETT 2023

- Many non-dcc can elicit dcc character behaviour (and vice versa)
- Experiments: Knobe's 20 non-dcc elicit dcc behaviour in new context, even though they don't elicit such behaviour in original context
- Context-dependent, flexible



BAUMGARTNER 2024

- Dcc arise through pragmatic effects
- Almost any concept can be a dcc
- Pragmatic concept modulation
- This cat is a real tiger.
- My friends are my real family.



KNOBE, IN A DEEPER SENSE

- Superficial features plus deeper values
- No fixed list of dcc, spontaneous creation of dcc
- Natural kind terms



'LIE' AS A DCC

- Concrete criterion: asserting something one believes to be false
- Abstract criterion: intend to mislead the hearer and extract an unfair advantage
- Concrete criterion unlike other concrete criteria

Consequence:

explains why bald faced lies are genuine lies 😊

no distinction between real lying and malevolent misleading 😞

Abstract criterion common between lying and misleading



The dying woman

A dying woman asks the doctor whether her son is well. The doctor saw him yesterday, when he was well, but knows that he was later killed in an accident.

- Doctor: Your son is fine.
- Doctor: I saw your son yesterday and he was fine.



- Knobe: There is a sense in which she is clearly not a scientist, but ultimately, if you think about what it really means to be a scientist, you would have to say that she truly is a scientist.
- Vs.
- Skoczeń: There's a sense in which what John said is technically not a lie, but ultimately, if you think about what it really means to lie, you'd have to say that there is a sense in which this was a lie after all.



'LIE' AS A PROTOTYPE CONCEPT

- Prototypical lie = a says something false believing that it is false with the intention to deceive



- Coleman & Kay, *Prototype Semantics: The English Word Lie* (1981)
- “pretheoretical intuition that semantic categories frequently have blurry edges and allow degrees of membership” (1981: 27)
- Meaning of “lie” based on prototype
- Prototype contains a finite list of properties, membership in the category “lie” is a gradient phenomenon; satisfaction of each property on the list contributes to the over-all degree of membership of an individual in the category; satisfaction of each property on the list does not necessarily contribute equally to degree of membership of an individual in the category” (1981: 27-8)



- There are no necessary and sufficient properties of lies
- Prototypical lie: false, believed false and intended to deceive
- “The notion of prototype definition suggests that utterances which have all three of the elements above would be considered full-fledged lies, and that utterances which lack one or more of the elements might still be classed as lies, but less clearly so; we might expect disagreement among S's as to their classification, and uncertainty on the part of individual S's. (1981: 28)
- Experiments



PROBLEMS

1. gradability

- It was {a lie / not a lie / I can't say}. I am {very sure / fairly sure / not too sure} most others would agree with the choice I just circled.

“We wished to obtain a scale of 'degree of lie' or 'degree of informant's certainty that the story contains a lie'” (1981: 30)

→ non gradable;



2. intention to deceive – what is its role (definitional???)

When is it legal to kill someone?

?*When is it legal to murder someone?

When can one lie without doing wrong?

?* When can one lie without intending to deceive?

Never, because murder MEANS breaking the law.

Never, because lying MEANS trying to deceive someone.

→ not definitional



- Role of the prototype:

≈ family resemblance

“complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing” (PI, §66)



- Role of the prototype:

≈ family resemblance

“~~complicated~~ network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing” (PI, §66)



OPEN QUESTIONS

- 1. Are there any necessary properties of lies?

The speaker believes that p is false (?)

Don't say: "There must be something common, or they would not be called games — but look and see whether there is anything common to all. — For if you look at them you will not see something that is common to all, but similarities, relationships, and a whole series of them at that. (Wittgenstein, PI, §66)

A family resemblance relationship consists of a set of items of the form AB, BC, CD, DE. That is, each item has at least one, and probably several, elements in common with one or more other items, but no, **or few**, elements are common to all items. (Rosch & Mervis 1975)

- 2. Is “reprehensible” part of the prototype?



SUMMING UP

- Conceptual analysis tells us that lying is a vague notion, not clearly defined
- 'Lie' is a prototype concept
- Deceptionists are mistaken: intention to deceive is not a definitional/necessary property of a lie
- We can explain why they are mistaken
- **Recipe:** Conceptual engineering – which notion of a lie do we need?



ST AUGUSTINE, *DE MENDACIO*

“But none doubts that it is a lie when a person willingly utters a falsehood for the purpose of deceiving: wherefore a false utterance put forth with will to deceive is manifestly a lie. **But whether this alone be a lie, is another question.**”



■ **THANK YOU!**



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